The Congress's Missionary Impulse and the Origins of the ABVKA

The most surprising thing about the creation of the ABVKA was the catalytic role played by a Congress chief minister. In 1946, when Ravishankar Shukla took over as premier of the Central Provinces and Berar (which later became Madhya Pradesh through reorganisation in 1952 and 1956), he was welcomed 'everywhere with enthusiasm and slogans of Bharat Mata ki jai were raised'. However, when he went to the tribal areas of Jashpur, 'black flags were shown and protest gatherings held' in several places.[9] According to an official history of ABVKA, published by it on its sixtieth foundation day, when Shukla questioned why he was facing such protests, he was told that the 'instigating elements (Christian missionaries and foreign elements who controlled them) were behind the scenes and it was like they were making the puppets dance'. Shukla turned for advice to veteran Congressman Thakkar Bappa (Amritlal Vithaldas Thakkar), a conservative Gandhian who had been working in tribal areas for years.[10] Bappa had founded the Bhil Seva Mandal in 1922 and been general secretary of the Harijan Seva Mandal founded by Gandhi in 1932. Because the Jashpur area had 'no nationalist organisation', he suggested to Shukla that the state open a 'Backward Community Society Welfare Department'. Bappa's confidante Pandurang Govind Vanikarji was sent as the director of this work. The department was established in 1947.

Working in Jashpur was difficult in every way, as Vanikarji knew it would be. However, he found an able candidate in Ramakant Keshav Deshpande, who practised law in Ramtek.[11] Deshpande, the RSS's city in-charge in Ramtek, had been arrested and sentenced to death in the 1942 Quit India movement, but was later released by the British.[12] This RSS pracharak, whom the ABVKA's history praises as being 'suffused in RSS ideals', was now handpicked by an appointee of a Congress chief minister. Deshpande and his wife first went to Jashpur in 1948.[13] He was hired by the state government to work on tribal welfare programmes there as area organiser. Atul Jog, ABVKA's national organising secretary, told me